International Institute of Information Technology, Hyderabad

(Deemed to be University)

Introduction to Human Sciences (HS8.102)

<u>Mid-Semester Exam: LITERATURE</u>

Max. Time: 45 mins **Max. Marks: 40** **26th, February 2026**

Attempt ALL questions. Each question is worth 10 marks, and the guideline for each is 150-200 words.

Instructions:

1. **Do not use bullet points. Write in full sentences and paragraphs.**
2. **Explain your ideas and examples fully and clearly.**
3. **Do not summarize the plot of a literary text. This adds nothing new. Your response should focus on your ideas and interpretations of the text.**

1. In the words of Terry Eagleton,

   "Part of what we mean by a 'literary' work is one in which what is said is to be taken in terms of how it is said. It is the kind of writing in which the content is inseparable from the language in which it is presented. Language is constitutive of the reality or experience, rather than simply a vehicle for it."

   Use either "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" or "There Will Come Soft Rains" and explain what Eagleton means.

2. What is the significance of the titles "There Will Come Soft Rains" and "The One Percent War"?

3. Define "fabula" and "syuzhet" using "The One Percent War" as an example.

4. How do different kinds of narration enable the way a story is told? Respond using "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" and "There Will Come Soft Rains." Consider aspects such as the first/second/third person narrator and different levels and layers of storytelling, such as who narrates and who speaks.

Grading Rubric

Overall points to note for the Literature module:

- Each question is worth 10 marks.
- An answer that gets the basic minimum should get about 5 or 6.
- An answer that gets the basic minimum and is written thoughtfully and thoroughly should get about 7 or 7.5.
- An answer that not only gets the basic minimum, but additional points mentioned below, and is written thoughtfully and thoroughly should get 8 or 8.5, with 8.5 being an outstanding response.

1. **In the words of Terry Eagleton,**

"Part of what we mean by a 'literary' work is one in which what is said is to be taken in terms of how it is said. It is the kind of writing in which the content is inseparable from the language in which it is presented. Language is constitutive of the reality or experience, rather than simply a vehicle for it."

Use either "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" or "There Will Come Soft Rains" and explain what Eagleton means.

- This is a summary of the basic minimum this answer requires for "There Will Come Soft Rains":
    - Meaningful, specific discussion of language and narration in the text (in other words, the "how" of the text - how the story is told). Such instances of language use that we have discussed in the class include: imagery ("Evil Baal," figurative language of destruction etc), words related to sound and touch, repetition, anthropomorphism/personification, the use of a poem within prose, the different tones in narration (italics - where the house "speaks" - and the rest of the narration, where the third-person narrator gives us a detached account of events) etc. Students should discuss at least three such different uses of language in detail.
    - This discussion of three uses of language in the text must be accompanied by examples of each that are correct and properly explained and connected to the argument. (Please note that the examples provided in the bullet above are not exhaustive/comprehensive. Students may come up with other examples from

the text. Check if they have used these examples correctly and grade accordingly. Please check with NA if there is any doubt on your part about this aspect.)

- For **"The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas"**:

  The basic minimum would require a discussion of the detail in description of Omelas, the creation of a point-of-sound over and above a soundscape, the peculiarity of a second person narration where the reader is talked to directly and the narrator suggests they don't know everything about Omelas, the vocabulary that carefully calibrates the nature of the place. The answer should cite specific instances from the text to elaborate. The answer must point out how the basement is described in contrast to the outside and what makes the basement a place with history. (The child can see that the outside exists by way of a few beams of sunlight, and "it" has a memory of a mother that "it" wants to go back to) What constitutes its torture? (Abysmal living conditions, a child with cognitive impairment living in its feces, too ill-kept to be gendered by sight, looks 6-7 years old when "it" is 10 years old).

- More points for students who do one or more of the following:
  - Point out that the "how" Eagleton mentions is basically what he also calls the "literariness" of the text. This literariness rests in the craft of language and other things, such as narration.
  - Anyone who tries to correctly explain what Eagleton means by the content being inseparable from the language and writes it well.

2. What is the significance of the titles "There Will Come Soft Rains" and "The One Percent War"?

This is a summary of the basic minimum this answer requires for "There Will Come Soft Rains":

- First and foremost, the title is a reproduction of the first line of a poem written by Sara Teasdale in 1918 (the author and date should be mentioned somewhere in the answer - this was discussed several times in the two classes on this text).
- The poem refers to a day when human beings will disappear/die, but nature will prevail. This is what seems to have happened in the story, and it is in this context that soft rain is mentioned. Students should be able to explain the connection between the title, the poem, and the story.

    - It is raining on the day the action in the text takes place.
- More points for students who do one or more of the following:
    - Discuss the "prophetic" nature of the poem, which appears to have been realized in the story. The title signals this prophecy or warning.
    - Provide examples or more analysis from the story and/or the poem. These examples should be correct/appropriate/relevant and should be fully explained and connected to the argument being made.

- **For "The One Percent War"**

  The title plays with the economic oligarchic class popularly known as the 1% – i.e., the 1% of the world's population that owns/manages over 80% of the world's resources on the one hand, and the built-in cost of using the *Equalizer* that is, one percent of a soldier's life on the other.

  More points for an answer that discusses that users of the suit do not know that there is a cost. Their deaths take fellow soldiers by surprise, and the tech of the bio-circuitry of suits is proprietary – owned by the 1%.

3. **Define "fabula" and "syuzhet" using "The One Percent War" as an example.**

Please consult the slides for Lecture 1. The definitions and descriptions are spelt out.

What they must get right to get the minimum

Fabula/Story: this is the world and the logic of events, emotional reasoning and arc

Syuzhet/Plot: The events and actions that let the story play out. The events could be set in linear or non-linear time.

More points if they can talk about non-linear events like flashbacks, memories, and flashforwards.

For **"The One Percent War":**

Fabula: A forever war, the two sides at stalemate, no winners/losers, a new suit gives one side a winning edge but takes lives, people acquiesce without protest.War is structured like a game to be viewed on a screen by actors who do not lose their lives.

Bonus for touching on any this: Soldiers are dispensable and briefly given the fallacy of god-like powers, control, and consent. Tech chips away at life without us knowing it.

Syuzhet: Federation vs The Eastern Pact, breakthrough military tech suit, the Fed starts winning lost ground again, soldiers start dying without warning, rumours, leaks, conscriptions, suits adapted to adolescent users, Ishan, a 12 year does not want to be God, his mother's "consent" is made automatic, more soldiers die, the Pact makes advances, compulsory conscription, and people are numbed into subjection.

4. **How do different kinds of narration enable the way a story is told? Respond using "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" and "There Will Come Soft Rains." Consider aspects such as the first/second/third person narrator and different levels and layers of storytelling, such as who narrates and who speaks.**

- This is a summary of the basic minimum this answer requires for "There Will Come Soft Rains":
    - First and foremost, the narrator is a third-person detached/unintrusive narrator.
    - The narrator has omniscience that appears to be complete.
    - The narration reads like a report.
    - A story like this (i.e. with the events that transpire in the story) requires a narrator like this. A detached narrator who merely reports what they see and do not express their thoughts or emotions about it allows for the "character" of the house to be the sole focus of the story.
- More points for students who do one or more of the following:
    - Argue that the "mechanical paranoia" of the house comes out more sharply and starkly as a result of the detached, unintrusive narration because of the singular focus on the house that such a device enables.
    - Argue that the fact that the house is "alone" and that there are no human beings and human activity in the house is heightened by this device of a detached, unintrusive narrator.
    - Point out that we have no way of verifying that the narrator has complete omniscience because there is no other entity apart from the house and the robot mice that has anything resembling "consciousness."
    - Stress that the narrator's very presence and eye-witness-like narration raise questions about who/what they are. This is an intriguing question because the story leads us to believe that there are humans around. If the narrator is not human, who/what are they? (Do not entertain speculations on the who/what question, since we are not here to diagnose the text. The questions are

significant in and of themselves and provoke thought, which is the point of a good story).

- Provide examples that are not only correct/appropriate/relevant but are explained well and connected to the argument being made.

- For **"The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas"**:

  1. The narrator starts out as a third person narrator but we realise s/he is not omniscient. S/he slips between the 3rd and the 2nd person, often addressing the readers with a "you." Ultimately s/he slips into a first person voice as well.
  2. The narrator, in addressing the reader, builds a world while talking about the s/he is building. The answer should address this with specific examples like, "For instance, how about technology? I think that there would be no cars or helicopters in and above the streets..." Even if they cannot quote the text in full, they should be able to pull specific examples.
  3. They should be able to point out that the moral problem of the story is made explicit in this switching of narratorial voice. The reader is shown how this perfect is made just right for them, except there is a problem. The society that is a fairy tale without being boring, idyllic without being stagnant, perfect without being numbing in ways that narrator also does not fully comprehend is based on the torture of a single child. The narrator asks the reader if the perfect world of Omelas feels more credible now that we know of the tortured child, thus forcing the reader to confront real conditions that makes prosperity.
  4. The third person voice slows down time when describing the movement of those who choose to leave. They should at the bare minimum mention this, and at best be able to describe how this operates – with descriptions of long unmarked roads, large fields, and repeatedly describing walking on and away.